

Introduction to Human Communication: COMM 108
Lecture Notes OUTLINE: Ch 4 Language

I. Language

A. Definition:

- i. Language is defined as a collection of symbols with arbitrary meaning that are governed by rules and used to communicate
- ii. Language and speech are different things
 - 1. They are interconnected
 - 2. Language is the mental/internal side of speech
 - a. You do not directly examine it
 - b. Language is indirect, you never directly assess it

B. Versus Speech:

- 1. Speech is physical, the external side of language
 - a. Any noise made by a person
 - i. A grunt, “um”, speaking, etc.
 - b. It gets directly examined
 - c. Up until you examine speech and make meaning out of it does not become language

II. Characteristics of Language

A. Language has Rules:

- a. Linguistic productivity
- b. Learning sets or systems of rules
- c. Familiar with all rules, not proficient in one
- d. You produce the meaning in your head

Ways to Study a Language:

1. Semantics:

- a. Semantics is the study of the units of meaning of a language
- b. Sometimes words, sometimes sentences, sometimes paragraphs, other times books
- c. Semantics breaks down and interprets the work

2. Syntactics:

- a. Syntactics is the study of a sentence structure of a language
- b. It is about grammatical composition
 - i. Where does comma go, where does period go, etc.

3. Pragmatics:

- a. Pragmatics is the study of how we use language in social context to achieve goals
- b. Getting your point across in a conversation

B. Language is Arbitrary:

- Words have no inherent meaning
 - Only agreed upon meaning and personal meanings for words
 - Meaning is in the person's mind
- a. Denotations:
 - i. Denotations are the agreed upon meanings for words
 - 1. Dictionary definitions
 - ii. More definitions can always be added
 - iii. It doesn't have to be in the dictionary only agreed upon by a group of people, this is called critical mass
 - b. Connotations:
 - i. Connotations are personal meanings for words that are usually connected to emotion and derived from experience
 - ii. You lived the world; you make meaning based off your experiences
 - iii. This can bring trauma, love, and heavy emotion to specific words
 - iv. These words will have meaning that traverse's denotation of those words

C. Language is Abstract:

- a. Words represent/stand for ideas, people, places, for things, etc.
- b. Language is symbolic
 - i. Words are just symbols
 - ii. They have no inherent meaning; they are just squiggles on a paper

III. Sapir – Whorf Hypothesis

A. Description & Versions:

- i. Description:
 - 1. Our culture tells us how to perceive our world, language expresses us
- ii. Versions:
 - 1. Strong version:
 - a. Language structure is necessary to produce thought
 - b. You don't have the capacity to hold thought without language

c. This was controversial

2. Weak version:

a. Language affects and reflects the way that we see our worlds

B. Linguistic Determinism:

- i. As an individual, language determines our thoughts, our thoughts determine our realities**
- ii. As individuals all of us have varying vocabularies**

C. Linguistic Relativity:

- i. Linguistic Relativity is on the cultural level**
- ii. Culture is a language community**
- iii. People from different language communities perceive the world differently**
 - 1. Sometimes true**
- iv. What hits the culture on a fundamental level**
 - 1. When a culture has many words for something it impacts the culture**
 - 2. When there is no word for something it is “not real” to that culture**